

appropriate policies and actions.

Washington has been at war with Al Qaeda and its allies for more than 15 years because it has military forces in the Arabian Peninsula and other Muslim lands; provides unqualified support to Israel; and supports and protects Arab tyrannies in Jordan, Algeria, Saudi Arabia, Egypt, and other Muslim nations. For an American to say these truths is to earn various unlovely sobriquets—anti-American, appeaser, anti-Semite—but for US leaders not to have said and accepted them has led only to defeat. India is in much the same boat, and if Indian leaders are looking to understand the motivation of the Islamists who attacked Mumbai and other cities, they might start with the following:

■ The Kashmir issue clearly incites Pakistani and Indian Islamists, as well as those associated with

Many readers will believe that such prose could only be written by a devoted India-basher. That would be natural, but it would be a mistake not to mull over the proposition presented. The Islamists India confronts are not frivolous men; they are serious, talented, and pious fighters who perceive that New Delhi's policies and actions—like those of the US—are meant to undermine Islam and hurt Muslims. And, as always, the beginning of wisdom lies in accepting that in most cases and for most people, perception is reality.

It would be an error to blame the Mumbai attack and other urban attacks in India exclusively on Pakistan. While the interests of the attackers and those of Pakistan mesh at many points, the Islamist fighters from Lashkar-e-Toiba, Jaish-e-Mohammed, Harkat-ul-Jihad-al Islami-Bangladesh, and the Indian Mujahideen are

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or inspired by Al Qaeda. Whether those Islamists are right or wrong is irrelevant. India's position on and actions in Kashmir motivates them.

■ New Delhi's support for the US-led war on terrorism; its nuclear co-operation with the US; and its joint exercises with US troops inside India also inspire hatred among Islamists.

■ India's expanding presence in Afghanistan is anathema to Al Qaeda, the Taliban, and the insurgent commanders who fought the Soviets in the 1980s. They are determined to prevent the creation of a large, permanent Indian presence in Afghanistan.

■ India's strong, growing, and very public military and security relationship with Israel is perceived as a threat by militant Islamists and ordinary Muslims.

■ For more than a decade, India's domestic politics have taken on—courtesy of Messrs Advani, Thackeray and others—a decidedly Hindu nationalist tone, one that is often anti-Muslim. This kind of politics and its accompanying rhetoric and media-play, together with events like the Gujarat riots, have angered Islamists internationally and appear to be creating a siege mentality among Muslims in India.

■ India's Muslim population has not benefited from the country's economic boom, lagging behind in almost all areas. These shortfalls also contribute to the Muslim community's perception of itself as the target of discrimination.

fighting for what they believe in. They are not automatons who blindly do Islamabad's bidding. And while there is every possibility that some Islamist fighters have been armed, trained, and otherwise supported by Pakistan—and that they have used Karachi-based Dawood Ibrahim's criminal infrastructure in Mumbai and across India—they are waging war, in the first and most important instance, in response to the impact of India's policies and the politics of Hindutva.

The foregoing is surely a strong medicine, but I believe that Indian political leaders and voters will have to take it thoughtfully if they are to defeat the threat posed by Islamist militancy. If there is some motivation needed for readers to face this reality, they might examine the pathetic plight of the world's sole superpower. Notwithstanding the massive reorganisation of the US intelligence community, the new doctrine for its armed forces, and the implementation of domestic anti-terrorism laws that border on violating civil liberties, America is now losing two wars and multiple smaller conflicts to its Islamist enemies. This ongoing, deepening disaster for the US is not the result of facing a more powerful foe. It is the consequence rather, of the refusal of US political leaders in both parties to act as adults and accept that the Islamists are motivated by what America does and not by what it thinks and how it behaves at home. Happy and fortunate are those who see and benefit from the mistakes of others. ■

